barter proposal, and here I made the offer irresistible for them and, at the same time, gave India the opportunity to learn a technology that was a closed secret among space-faring nations. I was told an average SEP engineer earned 25,000 Francs a month.

'Fifty Indian engineers will do the same work for 3,000 Francs a month,' I told Souffle and Morin. 'You save 22,000 Francs per person per month. That is 1.1 million Francs for fifty people. Which means you save 13.2 million Francs at the end of the year. If the project is to go on for five years, it converts to 66 million Francs at the end of the project.' That was some impressive mental arithmetic!

Before Souffle could reply, I dangled another carrot. France was making transducers for 14,000 Francs a piece. India will make it for half the price, provided the French transferred the technology and gave us machines and raw materials. Left unsaid was that the transducer deal, which I offered as a bonus, would add to ISRO's kitty an auxiliary asset.

But the contract threatened to fall apart just when it was to be signed. Souffle and Morin had been visiting India as much as I visited France to work on the contract. At one point, there was some serious disagreement over the transducer project. Besides some haggling over the transducer price, the French felt that India was getting the technology too cheap. The credit for ironing out these differences should go to Grover. When the French expressed their reservations over signing the contract, Grover came to me.

'Nambi, all your efforts have gone to the dogs,' he said.

When he explained the problem, I realised it was tough to renegotiate the deal; only some glib talk might salvage it.

'Now,' I challenged Grover. 'Show your salesmanship and get it done for India.'

Grover did just that. Souffle and Morin were in Bangalore, and Grover invited me for breakfast along with them at Windsor Manor. Grover had this compelling argument in favour of the contract. He told Souffle and Morin that it was much more than a joint-development of a rocket engine; that it